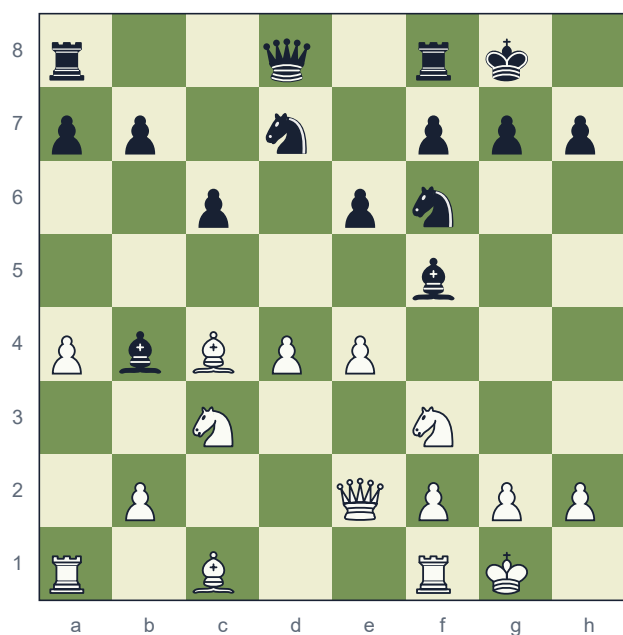


The Slav Defense

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Against ...dxc4 use a4 to restrain ...b5, then e3 and Bxc4. Keep a full central position without letting Black hold the extra pawn too cheaply.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The c6 pawn supports d5 while the c8 bishop can develop outside the chain. Unlike the QGD, Black has not necessarily blocked that bishop with ...e6.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black can capture c4, develop ...Bf5 or ...Bg4, play a waiting ...a6, or transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. a4 in the main line has a purpose: it fights ...b5.
2. An early ...e6 takes you to the Semi-Slav booklet; do not continue a Slav line mechanically.
3. If the bishop leaves c8 before the center is settled, pressure on b7 or d5 may become possible.

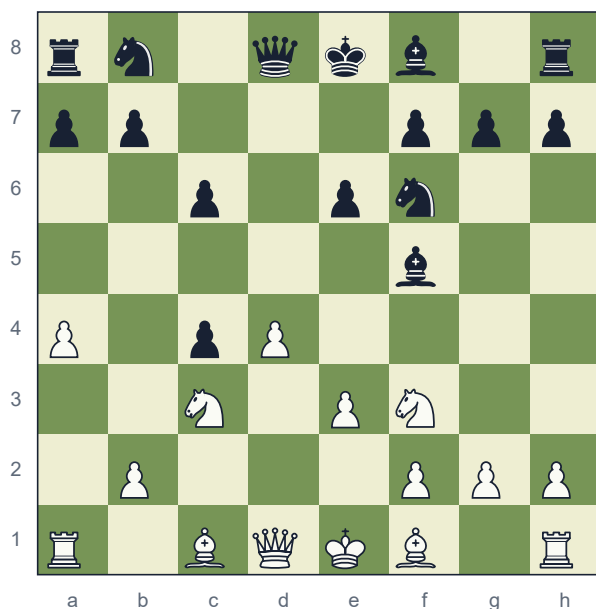
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main line with ...Bf5

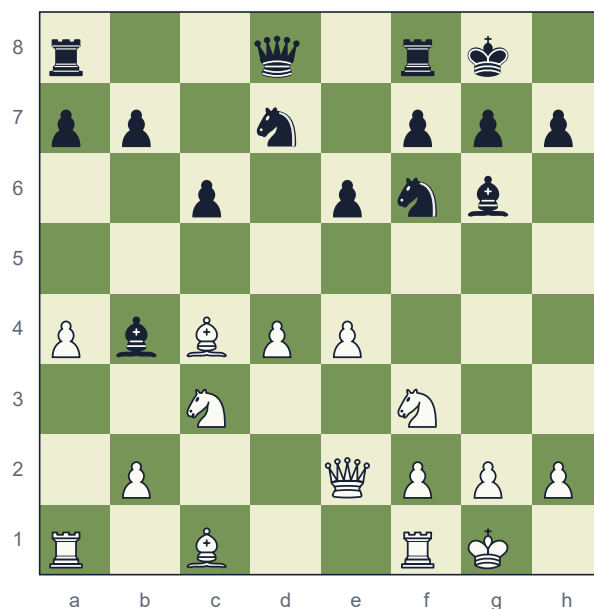
STUDY LINE 05-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O O-O 9. Qe2 Nbd7 10. e4 Bg6

Selected anchor ends with 10. e4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 restrains ...b5, e3 releases the bishop, and e4 later uses your central majority after development.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Support e4, develop the c1 bishop, and watch ...Bg6 or ...Bxc3. The d4-e4 center can advance only if the pieces behind it cooperate.

WATCH FOR

Do not confuse space with stability: ...Nxe4 may work tactically when the c3 knight is pinned.

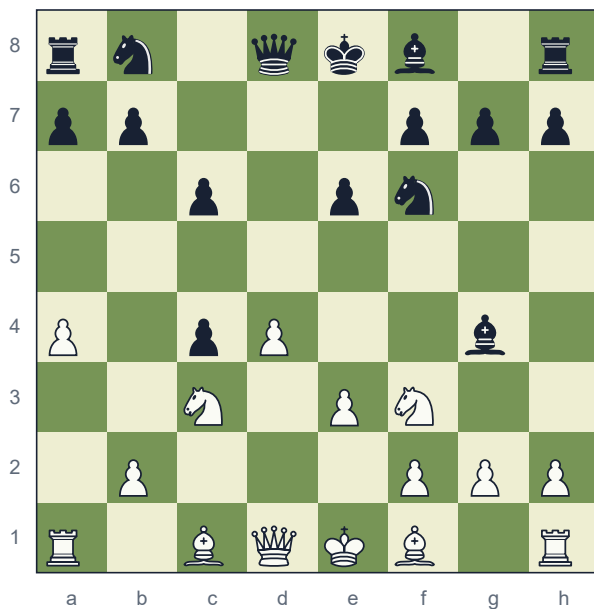
REMEMBER a4, recover c4, develop, then consider e4.

02 The ...Bg4 alternative

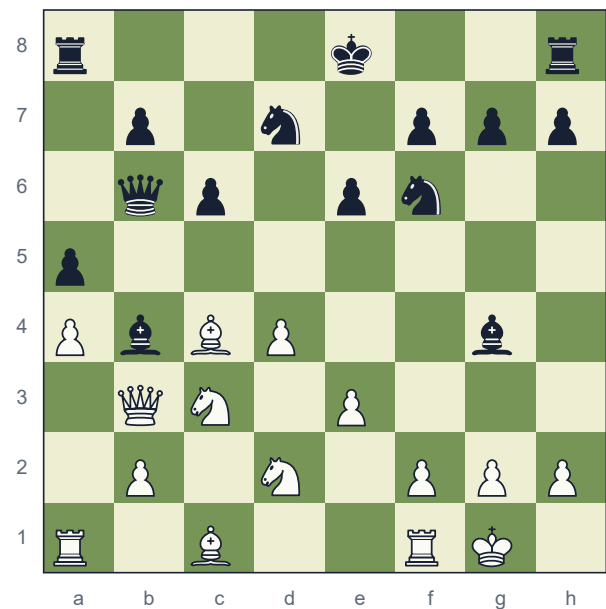
STUDY LINE 05-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bg4 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qb3 Qb6 10. Nd2 a5

Selected anchor ends with 8. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The bishop pins f3 instead of controlling e4 from f5. You can still use the main development scheme.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Meet pressure on d4 with active development. A timely h3 can ask the bishop to decide, but first ensure the central pawns are adequately defended.

WATCH FOR

After ...Bxf3, a queen recapture may abandon a tactical defense elsewhere. Count before recapturing.

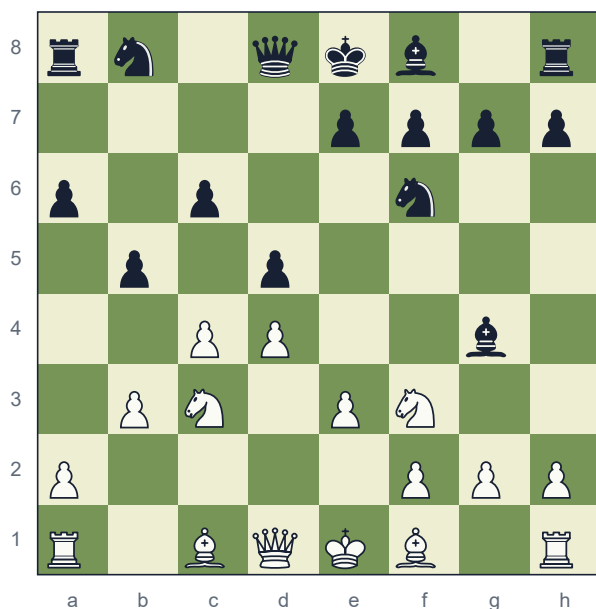
REMEMBER Same development, different pin.

03 Chebanenko: ...a6

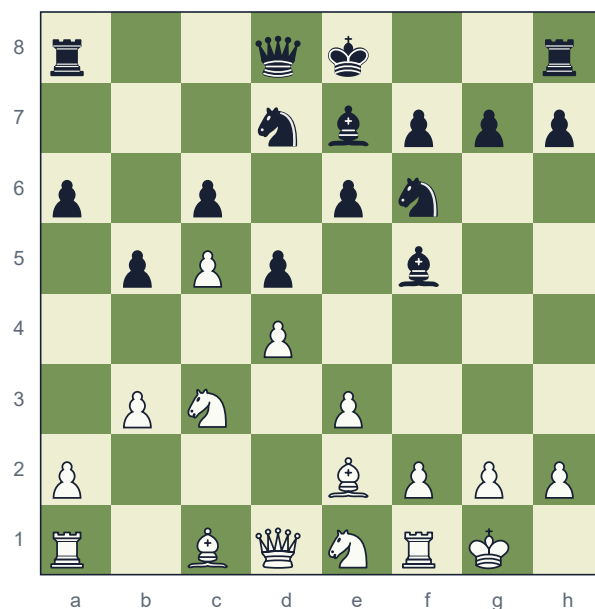
STUDY LINE 05-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. e3 b5 6. b3 Bg4 7. Be2 e6 8. c5 Nbd7 9. O-O Be7 10. Ne1 Bf5

Selected anchor ends with 7. Be2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 and b3 build a stable center while preparing to contest the long diagonal. Black's queenside expansion gains space but also creates targets.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle, finish development with Bb2, and challenge the center rather than racing the b-pawn without support.

WATCH FOR

cx b5 followed by a recapture can strengthen Black's central or queenside pawn mass. Calculate the structure before exchanging.

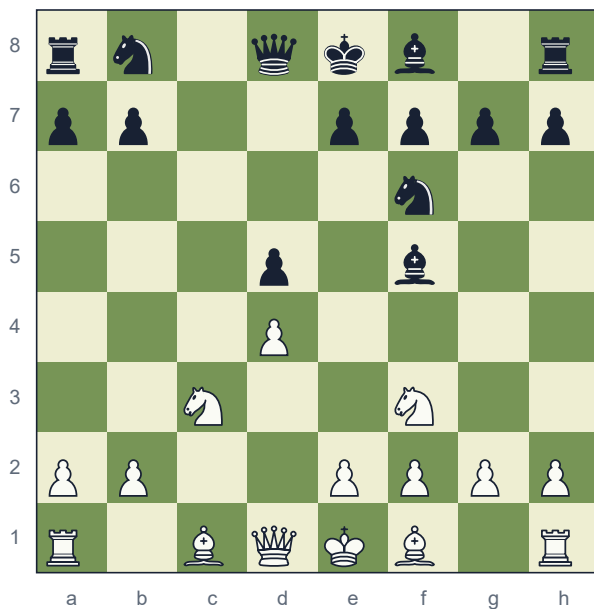
REMEMBER Let development decide when to challenge ...b5.

04 Early ...Bf5 before capturing

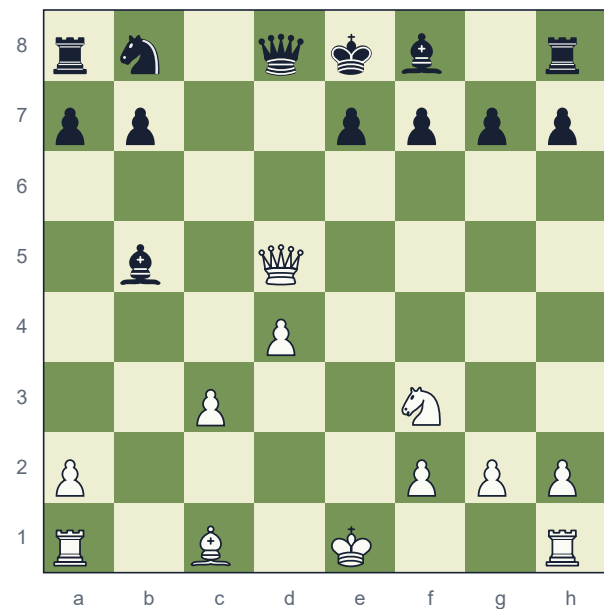
STUDY LINE 05-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Qb3 Bc8 7. e4 Nxe4 8. Bb5+ Bd7 9. Qxd5 Nxc3 10. bxc3 Bxb5

Selected anchor ends with 6. Qb3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The queen eyes b7 after the bishop has left c8. This makes Black account for the queenside instead of completing a setup for free.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop e3 and Bd3 if the queen raid does not win anything concrete. Pressure is useful even when you do not capture the pawn.

WATCH FOR

Qxb7 can trap your queen or fall behind in development. The threat may be stronger than the capture.

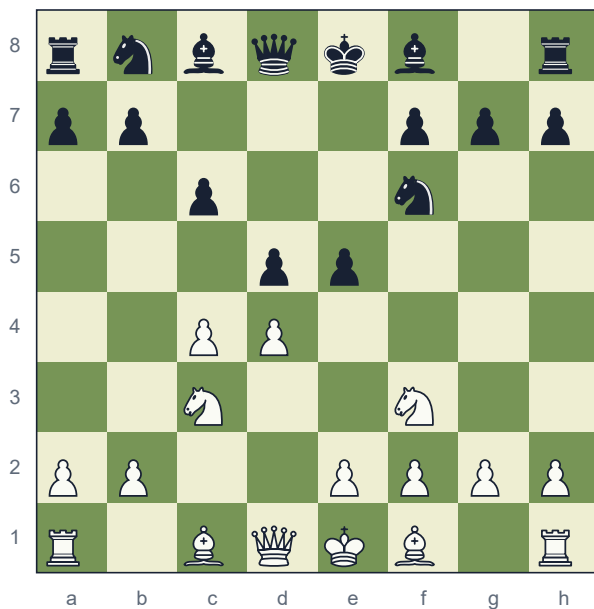
REMEMBER Attack the undefended point, but do not become greedy.

05 An early ...e5 counterstrike

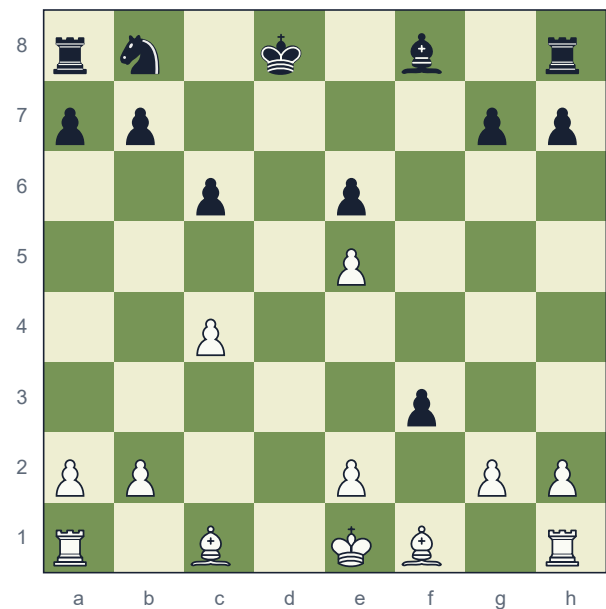
STUDY LINE 05-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e5 5. dxe5 Ne4 6. Nxe4 dxe4 7. Qxd8+ Kxd8 8. Ng5 Be6 9. Nxe6+ fxe6 10. f4 exf3

Selected anchor ends with 5... Ne4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Accept the central pawn and recognize that the knight leap is Black's source of compensation. The center is now tactical, not a standard Slav setup.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop actively and be willing to return a pawn to neutralize threats. Check queen checks and the c3 knight before choosing a capture.

WATCH FOR

Do not mix this ...e5 line with the Albin: the black c-pawn is on c6, and the knight is already on f6 before jumping.

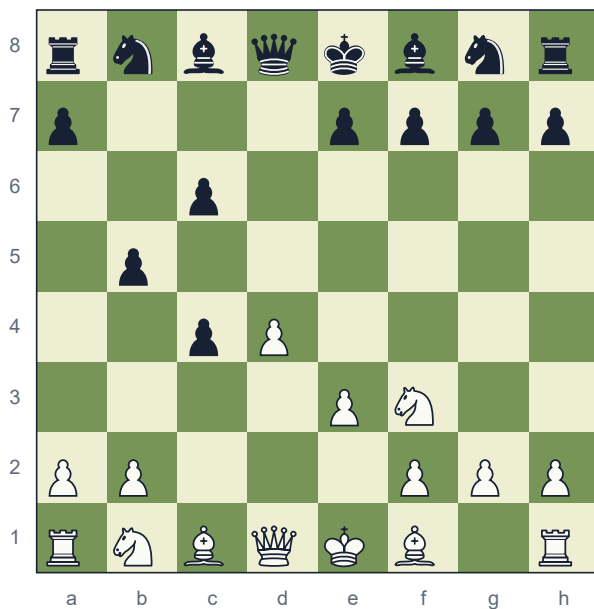
REMEMBER Identify the actual position, not just the word gambit.

06 Black captures before developing ...Nf6

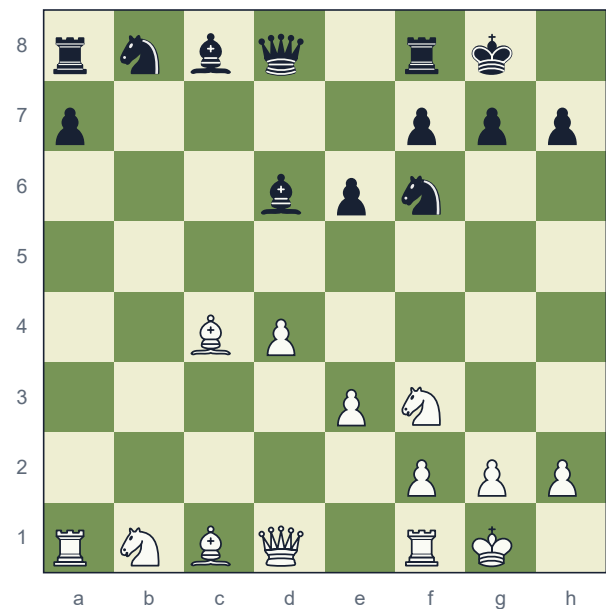
STUDY LINE 05-06

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 b5 5. a4 e6 6. axb5 cxb5 7. b3 Nf6 8. bxc4 bxc4 9. Bxc4 Bd6 10. O-O O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. a4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 prepares Bxc4 while a4 challenges the supporting pawn chain. Black has spent several moves on pawns instead of developing the king side.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

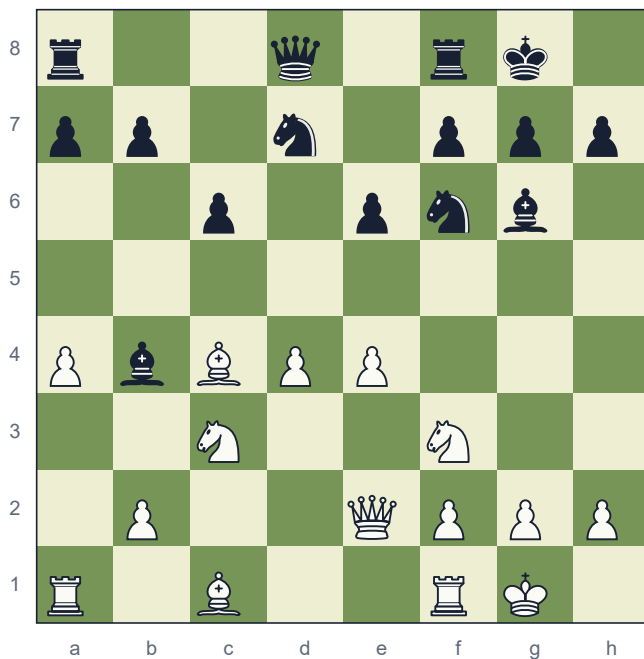
Recover c4 when safe and bring the king to safety. Watch a possible ...b4 before placing the b1 knight on c3.

WATCH FOR

The move order differs from the main Slav, where Nc3 was already played before the capture.

REMEMBER Challenge the support and use the development lead.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The c6 pawn supports d5 while the c8 bishop can develop outside the chain. Unlike the QGD, Black has not necessarily blocked that bishop with ...e6.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black can capture c4, develop ...Bf5 or ...Bg4, play a waiting ...a6, or transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Support e4, develop the c1 bishop, and watch ...Bg6 or ...Bxc3. The d4-e4 center can advance only if the pieces behind it cooperate.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.